6 Bold Moves in Banking

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Published: August 11, 2026 | White paper, with a supplemental video series

Source: PR Newswire, Finopotamus (Aug 11, 2026); crnrstone.com/gritty-insights research library

This document is an archival summary reconstructed from the press release, secondary banking-trade coverage, and Cornerstone's published research description. The full white paper is a gated free download; content here reflects the moves and framing as reported, not the complete original text.

Executive Summary

A white paper outlining six strategic moves bank and credit union leaders should consider over the next 12–18 months, given accelerating AI capability, intensifying fintech competition, shifting customer expectations, and a fast-changing operating environment. Cornerstone's central claim is a shift in diagnosis: the industry's binding constraint is no longer identifying opportunities for transformation — those are now well understood — but developing the discipline and focus to act on a small number of them decisively. The paper explicitly declines to prescribe a single playbook, instead challenging executives and boards to re-examine assumptions about growth, transformation, technology investment, and organizational agility.

The Six Moves (as reported)

- Abandon piecemeal modernization in favor of a comprehensive, roadmap-driven approach to technology investment.
- Focus on specific markets and products rather than chasing every available opportunity.
- Develop — and regularly revisit — strategic roadmaps rather than treating them as one-time planning exercises.
- Treat culture, including employee retention and customer satisfaction, as a balance-sheet issue, not solely an HR concern.
- Operationalize AI to raise productivity and improve customer experience, on the premise that banks which don't will fall behind competitors that do.
- A sixth move, on organizational agility and decisive action under uncertainty, is referenced in Cornerstone's framing but was not itemized with the same specificity in available secondary coverage; the full white paper should be consulted directly for its exact wording.

Why This Paper Is Significant

- Cornerstone is already a cited voice in the worldview canon — for the “only halfway” data-readiness finding and the “60% of banks lack AI KPIs” statistic — but this is their first full strategic framework in the canon, and it speaks directly to the worldview's “How to Proceed” phased guidance for banks rather than to a single supporting belief.
- It builds on Cornerstone's own 2026 “What's Going On in Banking” research (49% of banks and 59% of credit unions have deployed GenAI), giving the six moves an empirical anchor specific to this audience rather than general enterprise data.

- Move #2 (concentrate on specific markets/products) independently arrives at the same prescription as the worldview's existing McKinsey-sourced belief to “concentrate on one to three economic leverage points and go deep” — a second, banking-specific voice reinforcing that guidance rather than merely repeating it.
- Move #4 (culture and retention as a balance-sheet issue) is a genuinely new element not yet present in the worldview's workforce discussion — it reframes retention/engagement as a quantifiable risk rather than a soft HR concern, which is a useful sharpening for the one-generation validator-pool risk the worldview already tracks.

Implications for the AI Worldview

- HOW TO PROCEED / Phase 2 (concentrate on leverage points): cite alongside McKinsey as independent banking-sector confirmation of the same discipline.
- DATA QUALITY belief: move #1 (abandon piecemeal modernization) reinforces the existing Cornerstone-sourced belief that data/infrastructure readiness, not model access, is community banking's binding constraint.
- WORKFORCE / one-generation risk: add culture-and-retention-as-balance-sheet-risk as a sharper framing worth a line in Phase 1 or the workforce open question.